

RIGOBERTA MENCHÚ

Rigoberta Menchú was born in 1959 into a peasant family of Maya descent in rural Guatemala. She worked to promote the rights of Indigenous peoples during Guatemala's

civil war of 1960–

1995, and continues her fight today.

She won the Nobel Peace Prize in 1992.

**▼ MILITARY RULE**

Since 1945, most Latin American countries have, for at least part of the time, been ruled by military dictators who have banned democracy. One such dictator was Chilean general Augusto Pinochet (below), who overthrew the elected government of Chile and ruled until 1990.



Modern Latin America

Even though most countries in Latin America gained independence from Europe in the 19th century (see p.163), people with European roots have tended to hold on to power. The 20th century was a period of instability across much of the region, but in recent years most countries have been at peace.

The Great Depression of the 1930s (see p.187) and the outbreak of World War II had a disastrous effect on Latin America, which relied on selling raw materials to the rest of the world. Though many countries tried to improve their economies after the war, they had limited success, and poverty and the gap between rich and poor worsened.

This led to a series of military coups (in which power was seized from governments by armies) that put brutal dictators in control. Most of these were supported by the US, who used the excuse that they wanted to prevent these countries from falling

into communist hands during the Cold War (see pp.198–199). By 1975, only Colombia, Venezuela, and Costa Rica had democratic governments. The situation improved from the end of the 1980s as newly elected governments took power, and the 21st century has brought peace to many nations that have long suffered from conflict. But many governments are fragile, and inequality and poverty are still serious problems.

▼ UPRISINGS

Revolutionary groups have risen up throughout Latin America to overthrow corrupt governments. In 1979, the Sandinista National Liberation Front (below) of Nicaragua ousted the dictatorship of the Somoza family.

